Understanding Heart Disease

What is heart disease?

Heart disease is a group of conditions that affect the heart and blood vessels. The most common type is coronary artery disease, in which the arteries that supply the heart become narrowed by fatty deposits.

Common symptoms

Symptoms include chest pain or tightness, shortness of breath, fatigue, and palpitations. Some people notice swelling in the ankles. Symptoms can be mild, so regular check-ups matter.

How it is diagnosed

Diagnosis typically involves an ECG, blood tests and, in some cases, an exercise stress test or an echocardiogram. Your cardiologist will explain which tests are right for you.

Reducing your risk

Regular exercise, a balanced diet, not smoking and keeping blood pressure under control all reduce the risk of heart disease.